UCLA GRAD SLAM

JUDGING INSTRUCTIONS & GUIDELINES

UCLA Grad Slam Video Submission Preliminary Round

In 2026, UCLA Grad Slam will be blending the most successful elements from the last few years, featuring video submissions in the Preliminary round, live in-person Semi-Final rounds, and a live in-person Final round. Once again, we will have judging panels comprised of administrative staff, alumni, postdoctoral scholars, and donors. The intended audience for the video submissions are graduate students, faculty, staff, campus leadership, alumni, donors, friends and family of the presenters, and members of the general public.

GUIDELINES

Non-Specialist Audience

Student presenters should be judged on their ability to inform and engage with a non-specialist audience -- helping others understand and appreciate their research. Thus, you are not judging the merits of the research or impact on society. Rather, you are judging the students' ability to effectively communicate their research. As a judge, your ratings should be based on how well the student presenters explain their topic to people outside of their field.

Level the Playing Field

All disciplines are of the same value -- i.e., engineers, physical scientists, humanists and social scientists should all be considered to have equally valuable significance.

Intellectual Significance

When rating the "intellectual significance" of a presentation, please consider the significance and impact only within the context of the presenter's field of study/ academic discipline, rather than in comparison to the other topics or the perceived impact on society at large.

INSTRUCTIONS

Time Commitment for Video Submission Preliminary Round

If you are judging videos during the preliminary round, it may take up to 2 hours of your time collectively to dedicate in this role dependent upon the number of videos that will be assigned to you. The judging period for the qualifying round will be February 6 - 13, 2026, with scores and feedback due on Friday, February 13 by11:59 pm PST.

Single Viewing Only

To ensure that each judge has the ability to provide their feedback fairly, we ask that you only view the video presentations ONCE followed immediately by your scoring and comments.

Once all feedback has been received, and results are tallied, all video presentations will be available for additional viewing.

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SCORING

Criteria

Each judge will award up to 30 points based on the following criteria.

1. Clarity
2. Organization
3. Delivery
4. Appropriateness
5. Intellectual Significance
6. Engagement

Decimals

When scoring the presentations using the 1-5 scale, please feel free to award scores using half points to help differentiate among the presenters (e.g. 3.5, 2.5, etc.). Try not to rate all the presenters the same.

Timing & Deductions

Timing of each presentation will commence from the moment the student starts talking. Points will be deducted from the final score, beginning with a 1 point deduction at 3:03, and 1 point being taken off for every 2 seconds the speaker continues after that:

3:03 – 3:04	1 point
3:05 – 3:06	2 points
3:07 – 3:08	3 points
3:09 – 3:10	4 points
3:11 – 3:15	5 points
3:30 and over	15 points

Time frame

It is recommended that viewing and feedback be completed within a 10 minute time frame per presentation. The Grad Slam staff will tally the scores following the review process. If a student goes over the 3-minute limit, the Grad Slam staff will make note of it and adjust the score.

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FYI

Presenters Per Round

Based on the number of students who registered and submitted videos for the competition, you can expect to judge anywhere from 5-10 videos. Each video will be approximately 3 minutes long. The deadline for the students to submit the videos for the qualifying round is February 2, 2026. We will notify you regarding the number of videos you have to judge by Friday, February 6. You will have until Friday, February 13, 2026 to complete viewing and judging your assigned videos.

Photography/Videography

A UCLA photographer and/or videographer may be present at the final competition. Qualifying video submissions, any videotape footage, photographs, film and/or audio recordings will be used for UCLA archival and marketing purposes. No commercial use of the recordings are intended or will be authorized. Members of the media may also be present and covering the final competition.

Top 20 Semi-Finalists

Twenty semi-finalists will be selected from the video submission round to compete in the in-person semi-final rounds on February 25, 2026. The names of the semi-finalists will be posted on the Grad Slam website by February 19, 2026.

Top 10 Finalists

Ten finalists will then be selected from the semi-final rounds to compete in the in-person final competition on March 11, 2026. The names of the finalists will be posted on the Grad Slam website by March 2, 2026.

Live Broadcast

The final competition on Wednesday, March 11, 2026 will be broadcast live online.

UC-wide Competition

Support our 2026 UCLA Grad Slam Champion, who will represent the campus in this year's systemwide competition on April 22, 2026. Watch via livestream at: gradslam.universityofcalifornia.edu.

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HOW SCORING WORKS

Additional information on z-scores https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Standard_score

How do we determine a student's overall score?

For each student that you judge, your total raw score—calculated by summing the scores you assign to each of the 6 criteria—will be converted into a z-score. We convert the total raw score into a z-score in order to standardize the scores across judges. A student's final overall score is determined by averaging the z-scores they received from all of the judges.

What is a z-score?

The z-score measures how far (or how many standard deviations) a student's total raw score is from your average total raw score. For example, a raw score that is close to your average score will receive a z-score close to 0. In contrast, raw scores that are above your average score will result in a z-score somewhere between .01 and 3 (or -.01 and -3 for raw scores that are below your average score).

Why are we telling you this?

A judge who varies their total raw scores across students will ultimately result in higher and lower z-scores than a judge who gives most students the same total raw score, for example all 28s and 29s. We encourage you to vary your total raw scores across participants in order to ensure all judges have a similar impact on the final result.

Example

Each participant is given a score from 1 to 5 on 6 different criteria (organization, clarity, etc.). A student's total raw score from a given judge has a minimum value of 7 and a maximum value of 35. The following table demonstrates how z-scores differ across judges who use more or less variation in their scoring.

	Judge 1 Little variation across Scores		**Judge 2** Scores only vary for one participant		**Judge 3** Scores Vary (uses 3s, 4s and 5s)		**Judge 4** Scores vary (uses full 1-5 scale)	
	total raw score	z-score	total raw score	z-score	total raw score	z-score	total raw score	z-score
Participant 1	29	-1.57	26	-2.2	26.5	-1.37	16	-1.31
Participant 2	29.5	-0.89	32.5	0.18	28	-0.77	18	-0.98
Participant 3	30	-0.22	33	0.37	29	-0.37	22	-0.33
Participant 4	30.5	0.45	33	0.37	30	0.03	26	0.33
Participant 5	31	1.12	33.5	0.55	32	0.84	28	0.65
Participant 6	31	1.12	34	0.73	34	1.64	34	1.64

- For Judge 1, the maximum z-score of their top scoring participants is low compared to the maximum z-score of judges with more variation in their total raw scores.
- For Judge 2, most of the participants received high but similar, total raw scores. As a result, the z-scores of their top scoring participants is low compared to the maximum z-score of judges with more variation in their total raw scores.
- For Judges 3 and 4, judges who vary their total raw scores across participants, whether they use mostly 3s, 4s, and 5s or the entire 1-5 scale to achieve variation, yield z-scores across a similar range.

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JUDGING SCORECARD

Presenter's Name: _____

Judge's Name: _____ Date: _____

When scoring, the use of half points is permitted. EXCELLENT 5 4 GOOD 3 2 POOR 1	SCORE
CLARITY: Did the speaker provide adequate background knowledge to make the talk and the subject understandable?	
ORGANIZATION: Did the presentation follow a clear and logical sequence?	
DELIVERY: e.g., pace, enthusiasm, confidence, body language, eye contact, and vocal range.	
APPROPRIATENESS: Was the topic communicated in language appropriate to an intelligent, but non-specialist audience? (For example, did the speaker avoid or explain discipline-specific jargon and acronyms?)	
INTELLECTUAL SIGNIFICANCE: Did the speaker explain why the research matters to the field of study? If the student presents on collaborative work, was the significance of the student's unique contribution clearly specified?	
ENGAGEMENT: To what extent did the talk speak to your intellectual curiosity? Did it make you appreciate the topic and want to learn more about it?	
COMMENTS for the presenter (positive and constructive feedback, areas of opportunity):	